

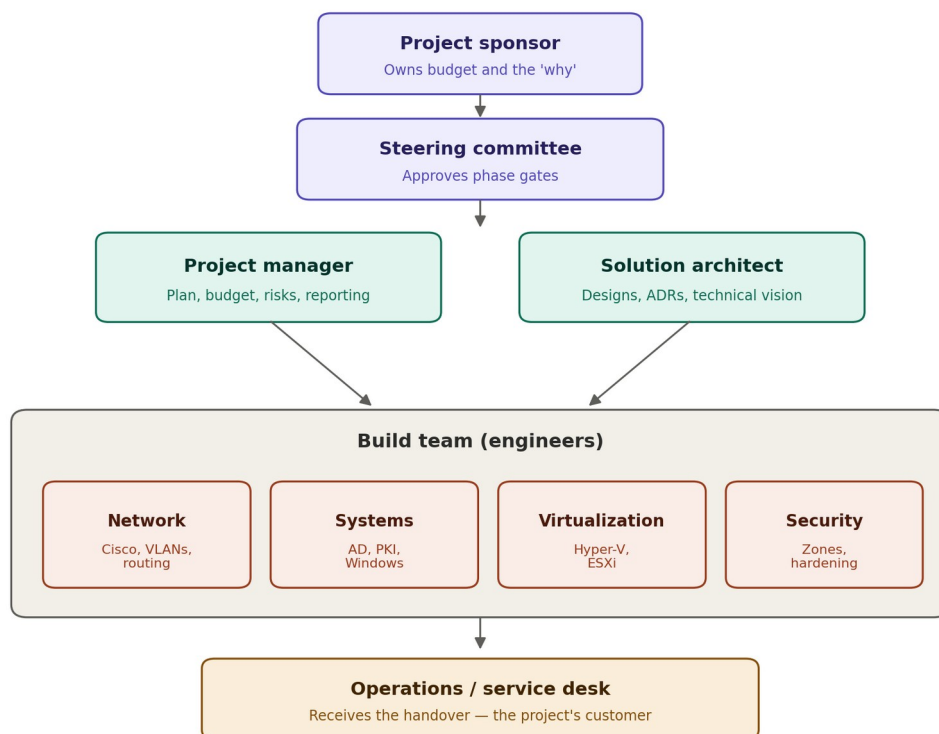
HOW THIS PROJECT WOULD LOOK IN A REAL COMPANY

Business structure, roles and resources — a handbook companion chapter · itc-hybrid-prj · v1.0

If our hybrid infrastructure project were executed in a real business, it would not be one person and a laptop. It would be a 6–12 month program with a budget in the hundreds of thousands of euros (people are roughly 70% of that), a formal organization around it, and money released in stages. This chapter shows that organization — because understanding the machine around the engineering is itself an interview-grade skill.

It all starts with a business case: a short document arguing why the investment pays off — for example, 'our current identity system blocks the cloud migration and fails the security audit.' Only when an executive approves that case does the project below come into existence.

1. The Project Organization



Each layer of this chart protects something different. Read it top to bottom as: the money, the plan, the quality, and finally the customer.

2. The Layers, One by One

The governance layer — protects the money and the 'why'

The **project sponsor** is an executive who puts their name on the business case and owns the budget. The **steering committee** (sponsor plus senior stakeholders — typically the IT director, a security lead, and finance) meets monthly and does one crucial thing: it approves phase gates. The project may not move from design to build, or from build to go-live, without their sign-off. This is why our project's phased structure is not cosmetic — it mirrors how money is actually released in companies.

The management and design layer — protects the plan

The **project manager** designs nothing technical. Their job is the plan, the budget burn, the risk register, stakeholder reporting, and unblocking the team. The **solution architect** owns the technical vision: the high-level design, the decision records (ADRs), and the answer to 'will these pieces actually fit together?' These two argue constantly and productively — the PM says 'we're late', the architect says 'we're not cutting corners' — and that tension is a feature, not a bug.

The build layer — protects the quality

Domain engineers, usually one to three per specialty: network, systems (the AD/PKI role — the one you are training toward), virtualization, and security. Each engineer works from the architect's design, writes the low-level design and procedures for their own piece, and raises a change request before touching anything shared. In a mid-size company this is four people; in a large one, four teams.

Operations — the project's customer

Operations and the service desk are not on the project, but they are who the final phase serves. The handover documentation, runbooks, and monitoring exist so that L1–L3 can support the new system without calling the project team. A project is not done when it works — it is done when operations accepts it.

3. The Roles Outside the Chart

Several roles deliberately sit outside the project, so that project pressure cannot compromise them:

Role	What they do	Why they are independent
Change manager / CAB	The Change Advisory Board reviews all change requests company-wide in a standing weekly meeting, and assigns maintenance windows.	Your project's changes compete with everyone else's. Someone neutral must referee. Our change-management SOP (Phase 0) simulates this.
Security officer / CISO rep	Reviews designs for compliance and security; can veto.	If security reported to the PM, schedule pressure could override safety.
Procurement	Negotiates and executes hardware and license purchases.	Engineers specify, procurement buys. The two-month lead time on network gear is a classic project risk.
Quality / audit	Spot-checks that documentation and procedures are actually followed.	Self-grading does not work; audits keep standards honest.

4. The Resources

Beyond people, a project like this consumes four kinds of resources:

Resource	In a real company	In our homelab
Budget	Hundreds of thousands of euros; ~70% is salaries.	Your time — which is why we pace it and protect it.
Hardware &	Servers, network gear, Windows/VMware	The lab gear we will inventory before

Resource	In a real company	In our homelab
licenses	licensing, support contracts.	Phase 1; evaluation licenses.
Environments	Three separate ones: lab/dev to experiment, test/staging that mirrors production, and production itself. Changes flow dev → test → prod.	One environment playing all three roles — an honest limitation worth naming in interviews.
Tooling	Ticket system (Jira), documentation platform (Confluence), version control (Git), monitoring, password vault.	Obsidian Kanban = Jira, the docs/ tree = Confluence, GitHub = Git. A near one-to-one mapping.

5. How Money and Work Flow: Phase Gates

The rhythm of a real infrastructure program looks like this — notice how each gate is a steering-committee decision, and how our own phase plan mirrors it:

Stage	Gate to pass before continuing
Business case	Sponsor and steering committee approve; budget is reserved.
Requirements & high-level design	Design review: architect presents, security reviews, committee approves.
Low-level design & procurement	Designs signed off; purchase orders released.
Build & test	Every change passes the CAB; test results verified against acceptance criteria.
Go-live	Go/no-go meeting: rollback plan verified, operations ready to receive.
Handover & closure	Operations formally accepts; project team dissolves; lessons-learned written.

6. What This Means for Our Project

In the homelab, you play every one of these roles — consciously. That is the whole design:

When you...	You are playing...
Write the project charter	The sponsor, writing the business case
Write an ADR or the high-level design	The solution architect
Maintain the Kanban board and pace the work	The project manager
File a change request against your own SOP	The engineer submitting to the CAB
Review your work against acceptance criteria	Quality / audit
Write handover docs and runbooks	The engineer serving operations — your former desk

The interview line this chapter buys you

“I structured my homelab to simulate the roles around the engineering, not just the engineering.” That single sentence tells a hiring team you understand how their machine works — and that you will slot into it on day one. It is worth more than any single technology on a CV.